

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Palm Sunday

The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love

For We Are the Ones

29 March 2026



"Even the Stones Cry Out"

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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Improvisation on ST. THEODULPH and ELLACOMBE
Paraphrases of two Preludes in C
When Felix met J.S.
Chaconne in G Major, BWV 1179
Variations on B-A-C-H

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Bull after Bach and maybe Bach
Bull after Bach and Mendelssohn
Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)
Christoph Bull

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 19 **Gavin Gregorio & Emily Kang**

Approaching Bethphage and Bethany, near what is called the Mount of Olives, Jesus sent two of the disciples with these instructions: "Go into the village ahead of you. Upon entering it, you'll find a tethered colt that no one has yet ridden. Untie it and lead it back. If anyone should ask you, 'Why are you untying it?' say, 'The Rabbi needs it.'"

They departed on their errand and found things just as Jesus had said. As they untied the colt, its owners said to them, "Why are you doing that?" They explained that the Rabbi needed it.

Then the disciples led the animal to Jesus and, laying their cloaks on it, helped him mount. People spread their cloaks on the roadway as Jesus rode along.

As they reached the descent from the Mount of Olives, the entire crowd of disciples joined them and began to rejoice and praise God loudly for the display of power they had seen, saying, "Blessed is the One who comes in the name of our God! Peace in heaven, and glory in the highest!"

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Palm Sunday Processional Hymn, led by our children and youth

***Palm Sunday Processional Hymn All Glory Laud and Honor**

ST. THEODULPH

All glory, laud, and honor to you, O Christ we sing,
To whom the lips of children made sweet hosannas ring!
The people of the Hebrews with palms adorned your way;
Our praise and prayer and anthems we offer you this day.

O Promised One of Israel, of David's royal line,
The one called 'God's beloved,' of flesh and yet divine,
To you, before your passion, they sang their hymns of praise;
To you, now high exalted, our melody we raise.

As you received their praises, receive our prayers today,
Whose justice and whose mercy and sovereignty hold sway.
All glory, laud, and honor to you, O Christ, we sing,
To whom the lips of children made sweet hosannas ring!
-lyrics by Jocelyn Marshall

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Holy One, of whom our Hosannas sing,
We give thanks for Jesus' example of peace,
as he rode into town on a donkey,
reminding us *this* is how you proclaim victory:
gently, humbly, turning the ways of war on their heads.
We desire to fan the flame of that example in our own time and place—
calling healing victory,
calling loving presence victory,
calling undoing the ways of empire victory.

*Come, O Spirit of Life, fan among us
the embers of the only thing more powerful than hate,
Love.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Sanctus" from *Misa de Los Angeles*
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

JUAN BAUTISTA SANCHO

***The Lord's Prayer**

Esme Gregoropoulos

*O God, Heart of the World,
revealed through every aspect of creation,
understood through our awareness.*

*May we honor the holiness of creation and act accordingly
so that your love is reflected in the way we live.
May we always be thankful for the food we eat
and the friends we have.
May we forgive those who transgress against us
and be forgiven for our own.*

*In the freedom of love, may we live as your heartbeat
and not be compromised by hesitation.
Through our freedom, may your justice
be seen and heard and experienced
forever and ever.
Amen and Amen!*

[Sherri J. Weinberg]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Claire Kelly & Esme Gregoropoulos

We are invited this morning
to open our hearts to the healing light
of the Holy One's encircling presence.

*We are invited this morning
to be aware of the gifts of this day.*

We ask that we will be surprised with small joys
and pieces of beauty scattered through the hours.

*We ask that the beautiful presence
of the Holy will help us this day,
to taste the joy that peace
with the divine life, and with each other,
can bring.*

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 19*

Emily Kang

Some of the Pharisees in the crowd said to Jesus, "Teacher, rebuke your disciples!"
Jesus replied, "I tell you, if they were to keep silent, the very stones would cry out!"

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Amen and Amen!

Reflection

For We are the Ones

Rev. Michael Lehman

Musical Gift

"Bach and the Mexican Baroque" Part 1

"Miserere Mei" movements 3 & 4
Laude

MANUEL DE SUMAYA

"¡O qué suave!"
Anna Caplan and Molly Pease, *Soloists*
"Miserere Mei" movement 6
Laude

ANONYMOUS SANTA CLARA MISSION

MANUEL DE SUMAYA

"Sanctus" from *Mass in B Minor BWV 232*
"Osanna" from *Mass in B Minor BWV 232*
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

J.S. BACH

"Benedictus" from *Mass in B Minor BWV 232*
Rohan Ramanan, *Soloist*

J.S. BACH

"Osanna" from *Mass in B Minor BWV 232*
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

We offer deep gratitude to the 100+ people whose financial contributions have made this morning and the special music this year possible. If you would like to join them with a gift to music, please leave a note designating "music" on your gift.

Translations

"Miserere Mei" movements 3-4, from Psalm 51
I have made choices that have separated me from love's understanding. On this path, I am lost, and that loss feels essential and justified. But behold, you, the God of love, are one with truth. You have shown me the uncertain and hidden aspects of your wisdom.

"¡O qué suave!"
Oh how gentle and sweet you are, exalted God of love, when, with a cloud, you so delicately hide your brilliant splendor. Let it ignite and burn in my heart, my Divine Love, in the pure fire of your sweet love.

"Miserere Mei" movement 6, from Psalm 51
Create in me a pure heart, O God, and renew my spirit so that I may walk in love.

"Sanctus"
Holy, Holy, Holy, God of the Sabbath. Heaven and earth are full of your glory!"

"Osanna"
Hosanna in the highest!

"Benedictus"
"Blessed is the one who comes in the name of love."

"Let Us Know Peace" Traditional Cheyenne Prayer
Let us know peace, for as long as the moon shall rise. Let us know peace for as long as the rivers shall flow. Peace, for as long as the sun will shine. Peace, for as long as the grass will grow, peace.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Let Us Know Peace"
Cathedral Choir, Tanner Pfeiffer, Conductor

JODI FRENCH

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

*Offering Prayer

Gavin Gregorio

Gracious and Loving God,
on this day we pray
that your Spirit might fill these gifts
we have given, and will give.
We also ask, Holy One, that we might
be filled and become vessels of your love,
your hope, your joy, and your justice in the world.
Remind us, O God, in these days of Holy Week,
that we belong to you and we belong to each other.
We pray this in the name of One,
who shows us the many paths that lead
to your Divine Presence,
and that flow from our lives through peace.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

May we be filled with a strength that rises
not from the clash of arms but from quiet courage.
Let us hold the weight of love like an offering,
knowing that true power lies in the gentle persistence
to heal, to soften, to mend what has been broken.

*In the tender pursuit of peace, we find the resilience
to endure, to breathe, and to be.*

-Kat Armas

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us!

***Hymn for the Journey**

Hosanna, Loud Hosanna

ELLACOMBE

Hosanna, loud hosanna, the little children sang.
Through pillared court and temple the lovely anthem rang:
To Jesus, who had blessed them, close folded to his breast.
The children sang their praises, the simplest and the best.

From Olivet they followed amid a cheering crowd,
The victory palm branch waving, and chanting clear and loud.
The God of earth and heaven rode on in lowly state,
And glad to see the children, slowed down the donkey's gait.

"Hosanna in the highest!" That ancient song is ours.
For Christ is our Redeemer, and sing with all our powers:
"Hosanna, Christ, we praise you with heart and life and voice.
Hosanna! In your presence forever we'll rejoice!"

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Variations on B-A-C-H – Reprise
Christoph Bull

Cathedral Choir members

David Harris, *Music Director*, Fahad Siadat and Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Directors*
Orchestra: Mishkar Fredell Nunez (*violin*), Ashley Salinas (*violin*), Andrew Waid (*viola*),
Alexa Haynes-Pilon (*cello*), Denise Briesse (*bass*)

Miriam Adhanom* | Jennifer Almiron | Marie Ash | Cruise Berry | Yulia Bilous
Christin Byrdsong* | Beth Braun | Donald Brown | Martha Butler | Anna Caplan*
Matt Carlson | Carol Crawford | Ruthie Condren | David Conley*
Michele Delliquadri | Katelyn Dietz* | Sarah Fuhrmeister | Henryk Golden
Daniel Goldman | Scott Graff* | Steve Gregoropolous | Brandon Harris*
Jeff Hindman | Tiffany Ho* | Frank Hobbs* | Jill Hornkohl | Laurel Irene*
Sharon Chohi Kim* | Paul Koleck | Adam Light | Scott Lyness | Jim Maslowski
Amin Musavikhah | Bonnie Mitchell | Katie Norman | Christopher Parsons
Molly Pease* | Tanner Pfeiffer* | Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz | Rohan Ramanan*
Yin Ruan | Saginaw Rozzo | Meg Russett | Nandini Sadagopan | T.J. Sclafani
Ilsa Setziol | Grace Sheldon-Williams | Maggie Stillman | Sabrina Tyas
Ivanna Vargas | Anya Vdovychenko | Jennifer Walls | Lorenzo Zapata*

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"This year we're celebrating Bach and the Mexican Baroque for both Palm Sunday and Easter. In a time when populist movements have become the last hope of the dispossessed, we look to the Palm Sunday story, and Bach's setting of the Triumphal Entry text from his "Mass in B Minor," for inspiration. The crowds cheered on the person they perceived to be their new military leader. They shouted "Holy! Holy! Holy!" as he rode into town on a donkey. Bach's setting of these words is hopeful, bright, and blasting. Over and again we hear a broad metered, triple pulsed heavenly outcry from humanity's streets. He follows this up with one of his most memorable fugues on the text "heaven and earth are full of your glory." He raises the energy further with a double choir call and response as if the crowd is shouting across to one another singing "Osanna." Finally, on the "Benedictus," he turns inward. Bach bends the promise of populism into the plaintive cry of a people. He uses the same internal triple rhythm, but transforms it into an invitation to compassion. This juxtaposition surrounded by such

essential beauty centers the narrative on Jesus' compassionate promise. As we celebrate the meaning that Bach's music has allowed us to find over the centuries, we also seek to uncover newness in the less-heard voices of Mexico's Baroque composers. Manuel de Sumaya, indigenous to Mexico, became one of the most renowned composers of the Baroque era. His music is lively, broad, and layered. His output has been compared to that of Handel and Bach. He led music at the main cathedral in Mexico City in addition to writing secular works for the stage and instrumental pieces. Sumaya's "Miserere" sings with a similar introspection to Bach's "Benedictus." The music hearkens to a modal era made crisp with his rhythmic sensibilities and fast harmonic changes. We open the morning with Juan Bautista Sancho's "Sanctus" from his "Misa de Los Angeles." His "Sanctus" is much shorter than Bach's, and embodies the thrilling energy of the story. Sancho lived most of his life near Monterey Bay. He was influential as a composer, and documented local cultures. The Baroque music of the Americas has much in common with European composers. Yet, the rhythms of the Americas are different, and the stories are told with an ear toward the earth and community that would have surprised Europeans of the time. We celebrate other music from the Mexican composers in what is now California with "¡O qué suave!," a piece of unknown authorship from the Santa Clara Mission. With a similar dance to Sancho's "Sanctus," this duet sings of the love at the center of the movement that compassionately confronted Rome's authoritarian cruelties. We end Palm Sunday with a contemporary work by American composer Jodi French. Set to a Cheyenne prayer, "Let Us Know Peace" hearkens to Bach's "Benedictus." It is a reminder that peace is a choice we can make, even in the most challenging times."